

Evidence and the Research Landscape

Level 1 - Research Foundations | Student Learning Pack

How to use this pack

Read the teaching sections first, complete the worked example, do the short practice task, then take the basic knowledge check in RSRE. External references are optional further learning; you should be able to answer the core assessment from the Academy material.

Lesson 1: What counts as evidence?

Health evidence comes from different sources, including primary research studies, systematic reviews, clinical guidelines, surveillance reports and policy documents. Each source answers different questions and has different strengths and limitations.

A research article may provide original data. A systematic review summarizes multiple studies using an explicit method. A guideline translates evidence into recommendations, often using additional judgments about values, resources and feasibility.

Lesson 2: Search before you repeat

Before starting a new study, ask what is already known. Search using the main concepts of your question. Record the databases or sources searched, key terms and important findings. The purpose is not to prove your idea; it is to understand the existing landscape and identify what remains uncertain.

Lesson 3: Evidence is not a popularity contest

Do not judge a source only by how impressive its journal or website looks. Ask: Was the study appropriate for the question? Was the method clear? Could bias have affected the result? Are the participants relevant? Are the conclusions supported by the data? A heavily cited study can still have limitations.

Lesson 4: Worked example

Suppose you find a news article, a cross-sectional study and a systematic review about malaria prevention. For a scientific background, the primary study may provide useful local data, while the systematic review may help summarize the wider evidence. The news article can help you understand public communication but should not automatically be treated as your strongest scientific source.

Lesson 5: Check your understanding

Your goal is not to memorize a rigid evidence hierarchy. Your goal is to match the source to the question and judge its quality, relevance, limitations and currency.

Competency check

After completing this module, you should be able to explain the core idea in your own words, identify a correct and incorrect application, and make a basic research decision using the concept.

RSRE note: The Academy is optional. Experienced researchers may use the diagnostic/competency pathway and enter other RSRE pillars directly.